

Masonic *Outreach*



WINTER
2025/2026

A publication of the Masonic Home of Missouri



Family

Mission & History

In 1875, MWB John C. Ralls presented the idea of “a ‘Home’ for the indigent widows and minors (orphans) of worthy (deceased) Master Masons ... to be located in some suitable and healthy place.”

Through the hard work of many, the Masonic Home incorporated in 1886 and opened the doors of the St. Louis Home to its first resident, a 12-year-old girl named Della Gale Farthing, in 1889.

The Home expanded into a full campus of service for indigent Masons and their families. The Masonic Home opened the Western Unit in Kansas City in 1986. In 1991, the Board of Directors made the difficult decision to close the St. Louis facility and relocate the residents living there. But also in 1991, the Board created the Outreach Program, a financial assistance program that could reach qualified individuals in their communities. In 2011, the Board of Directors also sold the Western Unit to focus 100 percent of its efforts on the Outreach Programs.

Outreach expanded from one program to 10, each satisfying a slightly different need throughout the Masonic Family. Three provide financial assistance to Masons, their wives or widows, ladies of the Eastern Star, and their dependent children. Three Partnership Programs partner with Lodges and Chapters throughout the state to provide for needy children, help their fellow Brothers and Sisters with a project, help send veterans on Honor Flights, and give care packages to active military. The final four programs are non-financial, serving the membership through financial education, honoring Masonic widows and veterans, and providing information on community resources.

We encourage you to check us out on our website at mohome.org or give us a call at (800) 434-9804.

MAIN CONTACT INFORMATION

Masonic Home of Missouri

6033 Masonic Dr., Ste. A, Columbia, MO 65202

Phone: (573) 814-4663 | Toll Free: (800) 434-9804

Fax: (573) 814-4660

Website: mohome.org

Masonic Complex Hours:

Monday through Friday, 8:30 a.m. to 5:00 p.m.

Closed for State and Federal Holidays

Masonic Museum Hours: (At the Masonic Complex in Columbia, MO)

Monday through Friday, 9:00 a.m. to 4:30 p.m.

Barbara Ramsey, Executive Director

bramsey@mohome.org | Ext. 209

Jodi Blake, Director of Finance & Fund Development

jblake@mohome.org | Ext. 212

DEVELOPMENT & COMMUNICATIONS

Jackie Walters, Sr. Engagement & Major Gifts Officer

jwalters@mohome.org | Ext. 214

Molly Rhodes, Marketing & Communications Coordinator

mrhodes@mohome.org | Ext. 230

MASONIC HOME PROGRAMS

Long-Term Financial Assistance

Sonya Swanson, Financial Assistance Caseworker

sswanson@mohome.org | Ext. 218

Short-Term Financial Assistance, Financial Education, & Children's Outreach

Carly Dibben, Financial Assistance & Education Program Manager

cdibben@mohome.org | Ext. 217

Allyson Reynolds, Financial Assistance Caseworker

areynolds@mohome.org | Ext. 219

Creating-A-Partnership (CAP), Partnering To Honor (PTH)

Letitia "Tisha" Woodard, Partnership Coordinator

twoodard@mohome.org | Ext. 210

Widows Program, Masonic Family Cares Program

Chantana Irvin, Masonic Family Cares Coordinator

cirvin@mohome.org | Ext. 239

Veterans Program, Museum, & Masonic Complex Calendar

Michelle Phillippe, Administrative Building Coordinator

mphillippe@mohome.org | Ext. 213



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Lodge No. 345



4	Executive Director's Notes
5	Thank You
9	Giving
12	Client Success
18	Museum Moment
26	Legacy
31	Program Spotlight
35	In The News
37	Health
38	Agency Spotlight
41	Financial
44	By the Numbers
46	Meet A Mason

EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR'S NOTES

Family is a word that means many things to many people. When I talk, I often refer to the Masonic Home family — the clients, donors, Board Members (current and former), staff, and members connected to the Masonic Home throughout the state. What I love so much about this particular magazine is the reminder that the same sense of family that I feel with the Masonic Home has existed for well over a century.

The lovely lady on the cover is Frances. She is a former child resident of the Masonic Home. While I have read stories about the Masonic Home's orphanage on Delmar, reviewed reports in the Grand Lodge of Missouri Proceedings, and looked at photographs and artifacts in the Masonic Museum connected to the orphanage, spending the afternoon listening to Frances tell stories of her time there was extraordinary. It reminded me of the extreme poverty children faced around the Great Depression, before government programs were created to help vulnerable children — children like Frances and her sisters. I am very grateful to Frances for bringing the Masonic Home's orphanage alive for me to see through her eyes and her memories. Frances was part of our Masonic Home family then, and she continues to be part of it today.

Frances and her sisters were provided a place at the Masonic Home because Missouri Masons intervened when their father passed away, and they had no other family. I think about those men who intervened for Frances but also supported the Masonic Home so she had a safe loving place to grow and thrive. I cannot help but smile as I read the articles in this magazine about Ken Johnson and Barry Jenkins. These are just two of the remarkable Masons all across this state making a difference. They are making it possible for the Masonic Home to help children today through our Children's Outreach and Creating-A-Partnership programs.

Whether it is through their philanthropic efforts or helping to work the programs and spread the word, they are doing today for children in need what the Masons of the past did for Frances. Ken and Barry are valued members of our Masonic Home family, and I am deeply grateful to both of them.

There are many great articles in this magazine, but I would ask that you please take a moment to read the Legacy article. This particular article highlights generational giving to the Masonic Home — a family that has come together as individual donors to be part of the Masonic Home's family. It is particularly fitting that they are featured in this magazine that is about family. To Delano, Cindy, Keva, and Matt — you inspire me.

For everyone that is already connected to the Masonic Home, I want to say thank you. We welcome you to be part of our family — something that has stood the test of time. Frances reminds us that the impact you make on a child today can change his or her life forever. It is often commented that I am passionate about the Masonic Home, because I am. I know the good work the Masonic Home is doing. I know the lives that we change. I am inspired by the people we feature in this magazine, and I know that we can do more.

As we prepare for the New Year, I would ask that you either renew your commitment to the Masonic Home family or you learn more about the Masonic Home and become part of our family. We invite you to learn more about our programs to help us reach more people. We hope that the work the Masonic Home does will inspire you to financially support our programs, if you are able. Thank you again to everyone that is part of our Masonic Home family and thank you in advance to those planning to join us.

I wish you all a joyous holiday season and a very happy New Year.



A handwritten signature in black ink that reads "Barbara Ramsey". The signature is written in a cursive, flowing style.

Barry Jenkins – 2025 Masonic Home Representative of the Year

By Gabby Gazaille

A Mason for nearly 50 years and an employee of Silver Dollar City for more than 45 years, RWB Barry W. Jenkins has served as the Masonic Home Representative for Table Rock Lodge No. 680 since 2019.

At the October Annual Session of the Grand Chapter of Missouri, Order of the Eastern Star, Barry was honored as the Masonic Home Rep of the Year, recognizing his outstanding dedication and service to the Masonic Home of Missouri.

“Barry truly understands the heart of the Masonic Home,” Executive Director Barbara

“Barry truly understands the heart of the Masonic Home.”

—Executive Director
Barbara Ramsey

Ramsey said. “He embodies compassion and service in everything he does, and we could not think of a more deserving person.”

In this exclusive Q&A, we sat down with Barry to learn more about his journey in Masonry, what inspires his work as a Masonic Home Rep, and what this special recognition means to him.

What does being recognized as the Masonic Home Rep of the Year mean to you?

It means the world to me because I try to work hard to



Barry admires his Masonic Home Rep of the Year plaque.

THANK YOU

make sure our veterans are honored and that people truly understand what the Masonic Home does. Whenever I do a flag presentation, I also share a Masonic Home presentation — those go hand in hand. I swell up with pride knowing how many people the Masonic Home helps every year.

What has your journey in Masonry looked like?

My dad was a Mason and a veteran — he is the one who inspired me. I became a Mason right out of high school, February 29, 1980, and have been part of Table Rock Lodge No. 680 ever since. I have served as Worshipful Master and am currently the Chaplain. Masonry and service are just part of who I am.

What led you to become a Masonic Home Rep?

I did not know much about the Masonic Home at first. When my mom was in a nursing home, I was paying out of pocket for her care and did not realize there might have been help available. Later, I started learning about the Masonic Home through mentors, visiting facilities, and seeing the good it does. I thought, there are so many people who do not know about this — someone needs to share it. Every time I visit a

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Masonry and service are just part of who I am.

—RWB Barry W. Jenkins



Barry and his wife, Linda, smile for a photo at the 18th Annual Truman Club Dinner.

Lodge or Chapter and give a presentation, I hear, "I did not know the Masonic Home did that!" That is what keeps me going.

What did your experience as a Masonic Home Ambassador and Board Member mean to you?

Being appointed to the Grand Lodge of Missouri Advancing Line was an honor — I learned so much in a short time. Stepping down for health reasons was hard, but being able to continue as a Masonic Home Rep and later as an Ambassador meant a lot to me. It deepened my understanding of how the Masonic Home works and how much impact it has. I have always wanted to do as much as I can to support it, even if that means smaller steps these days.

What projects or partnerships has your Lodge supported through the Masonic Home?

One of the projects I am proud we supported was the Blue Eye R-V School District. I was surprised to learn how often teachers spend their own money on essentials for students in need. Our Lodge wanted to help make sure those kids were taken care of and to ease that burden on teachers.

What advice would you give to someone newly appointed as a Masonic Home Rep?

To learn everything you can about the programs. The website is a great resource, but I also encourage attending trainings and presentations — you can always learn something new. When you present to your Lodge, be confident and passionate — explain why these programs matter and how they change lives. That is what helps others want to get involved.

Is there anything else you would like to share about being a Masonic Home Rep?

I just feel honored. Even though my health slows me down a little, I will keep doing whatever I can. My wife, Linda, helps a lot — she was Worthy Matron last year and even led one of the programs with her Chapter. It is something we enjoy doing together. The Masonic Home really does incredible things, and I am proud to be a small part of that.

Barry's humility, experience, and heart for service reflect the true spirit of the Masonic Home of Missouri. Congratulations, Barry, and thank you for your years of dedication and compassion.

Get involved with the Masonic Home's Outreach Programs

Veterans Program

Honor a Brother or Sister who has served our country by requesting a Veterans Flag Presentation through the Masonic Home.

Creating-A-Partnership (CAP) Program

Help children in need within your community — whether it is helping pay unpaid school lunch balances, providing school supplies and other essentials, or supporting the Buddy Backpack program. Partner with the Masonic Home to turn these needs into meaningful outreach.

Long-Term Financial Assistance (LTA) Program

Refer yourself or a Brother or Sister who may need help paying the entire cost of their care needs and living expenses. Be an advocate by promoting LTA in your Lodge, Chapter, and on social media to ensure members of the Masonic Family know help is available.



mohome.org

Masonic Home Representatives

We Need You!

Be the bridge between your Lodge or Chapter and the Masonic Home of Missouri.

As a Masonic Home Representative, you play a vital role in connecting Masons, Eastern Star members, and their families to the support and services that make a difference in their lives. You are the voice that helps share our mission — ensuring that every Mason and Eastern Star member in Missouri knows the Masonic Home is here when they need it most.

Stay informed by keeping up with our latest news and programs. Share important updates during Lodge or Chapter meetings, and help others understand how our Outreach Programs can change lives.

Engage online by following and sharing the Masonic Home's social media posts. Spread the word about our events, online campaigns, and stories of impact. The more people you reach, the stronger our network of care becomes.

Your involvement as a Masonic Home Representative helps extend the legacy of Masonic relief and support across Missouri — one conversation, one connection, and one act of kindness at a time.

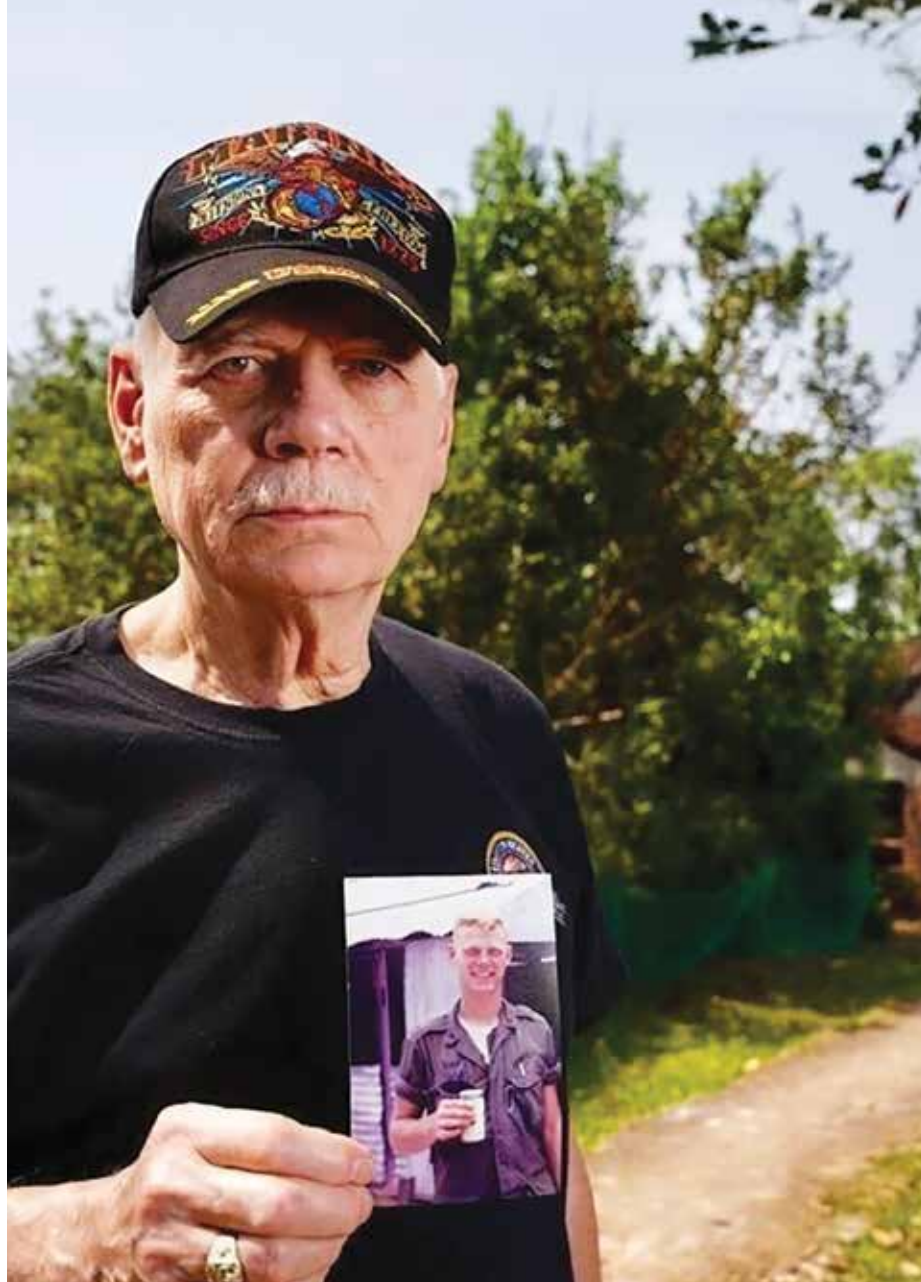
For more information on what it means to be a Masonic Home Rep, visit mohome.org/about-us/masonic-home-representatives or Scan the QR code.



**Working Together.
Succeeding Together.**

The Power of Quiet Giving

By Jodi Blake



Ken proudly holds a photo from his time in the service.

In a world that often prioritizes accolades and recognition, Ken Johnson stands out for this humility and service. With a story that reflects a deep commitment to his country, his Masonic Lodge, and the values of community, Ken's life journey highlights the beauty of quiet dedication and the impact of giving.

Ken's connection to Masonry was inspired by his father, who introduced Ken and his brother

to Lodge. But, Ken did not become active until later in life. When he did, he devoted himself wholeheartedly to his Lodge, participating in meetings, learning the lectures, and taking on the role of Treasurer for many years.

With support from their father, a shared vision, and the spirit of teamwork, Ken and his brother pooled their resources and started a cabinetry business from their garage. The family business

flourished. Upon retirement, the brothers transitioned ownership to the foreman, who had been with them from the beginning. This decision shows the brothers' loyalty and respect for those who contributed to their success.

Ken's life has always been intertwined with service. Not knowing what life had in store for him, he joined the military before his 18th birthday. In 1965, his unit was given a one-week



Ken stands for a photo during his trip to Hanoi, also known as the City for Peace.



Ken, Linda (his wife) and a military brother smile for a photo.

notice to pack up and ship out to Vietnam. Upon returning, he raised a family and never looked back, until he reconnected with some of his military brothers on Facebook fifty years later. They planned a reunion, and several returned together to Vietnam, visiting where they were stationed in South Vietnam. “It was the trip of a lifetime,” he said, reflecting on the shared experiences that created lifelong bonds.

Ken says he has a reputation as being conservative with money, but he would describe it as being wise with his investments. This strategy, along with a successful business, has afforded him the ability to support his Masonic community in impactful ways, including a heartfelt donation

toward Lodge maintenance in 2024, a significant contribution to the Masonic Home in 2025, and many behind-the-scenes donations to help those around him. His generosity has extended quietly to his fellow Masons as well; he stepped in anonymously to pay dues for two Brothers. Supporting his Brothers, especially his mentors, is very important to Ken.

It is no surprise, then, that Ken was drawn to support the mission of the Masonic Home of Missouri. He said he knows the money “will be distributed to those in need. It will go to the right places, to the people who really need it.” Ken had been giving to the Masonic Home for several years, and he decided to make a significant contribution

this year to sponsor a gallery in the Masonic Museum.

Ken’s humility is especially striking when discussing his contributions. To his museum plaque, he added the quote, “Charity extends beyond the grave, through the boundless realms of eternity.” When asked why, he simply stated, “It resonated with me.” This speaks to Ken’s character. For Ken, donating to the Masonic Home was not about personal acknowledgment; it was a way to ensure that funds reached those genuinely in need. “I hope this donation will help a little bit,” he remarked, emphasizing the importance of community support.

Ken describes his life as “pretty normal,” filled with moments that

have shaped him into the man he is today. During moments of introspection, he expresses that he wishes he would have done more and been more active. He says, “Life goes by too fast, you can never do enough.”

As Ken reflects on his time and contributions, there’s a wisdom born from experience. In the face of mortality, he remains practical, yet deeply sensitive and reflective. The conversations about his legacy show an emotional depth that invites us all to consider our own journeys, reminding us to live each day fully and with intention.

“Life goes by fast-faster than you want. You do not want to regret anything that you do,” he advises, a reminder of the importance of seizing the moment. For Ken Johnson, the true measure of a life well lived is not in accolades but in the quiet moments of kindness, the dedication to service, and the bonds formed within a community.

In telling Ken’s story, we celebrate a man whose humility and service enrich not only his life but also the lives of those around him, leaving a lasting legacy of generosity and reflection for generations to come.



Ken’s son, Brother Carl, presents WB Ken with his 50-Year Pin.



WB David Caraballo recognizes Ken for his 50 years of service to the Craft.



This plaque hangs in the entry way to the Missouri Masonic Museum in recognition of Ken’s kind donation.



Frances Wind (formerly Latham) smiles alongside her daughter, Barbara.

Family

By Molly Rhodes

A word that carries deep meaning and one that looks different for everyone — family. For some, it is defined by blood, ancestry, and last names. For others, family is made of people who step into the gap when life creates a void — those who offer not just a place to stay, but a place to belong.

For Vera Frances Latham, family did not always look like the one she was born into. Vera Frances was admitted to the Masonic Home in May 1931 at the age of six. Her sisters, Ella Mae Latham, age thirteen, and Velma Ruth Latham, age ten, entered alongside her.

The three sisters grew up on a farm in a one-bedroom house where their father worked for the farmer who owned the land. The house had no facilities, and winters were “no fun,” as Frances remembered — especially when the outhouse sat twenty feet from the front door.

Her mother passed away when she was very young, and later, her father passed, leaving the three girls with no relatives close enough to care for them. The farmer who owned the land saw the desperate need and turned to those he believed could help: his Masonic Brothers.

CLIENT SUCCESS

Although the Latham sisters had no Masonic affiliation, he shared their story with the Lodge members, who were determined to find a place for them.

That place was the Masonic Home of Missouri, then located on Delmar Street in St. Louis. Although it had been founded to care for the widows and orphans of worthy, deceased Masons, the Masonic Home opened its doors to Frances and her sisters despite

their lack of Masonic ties. They were not simply admitted — they were embraced. For three young girls with no place to belong, that acceptance meant everything.

Life at the Original Masonic Home

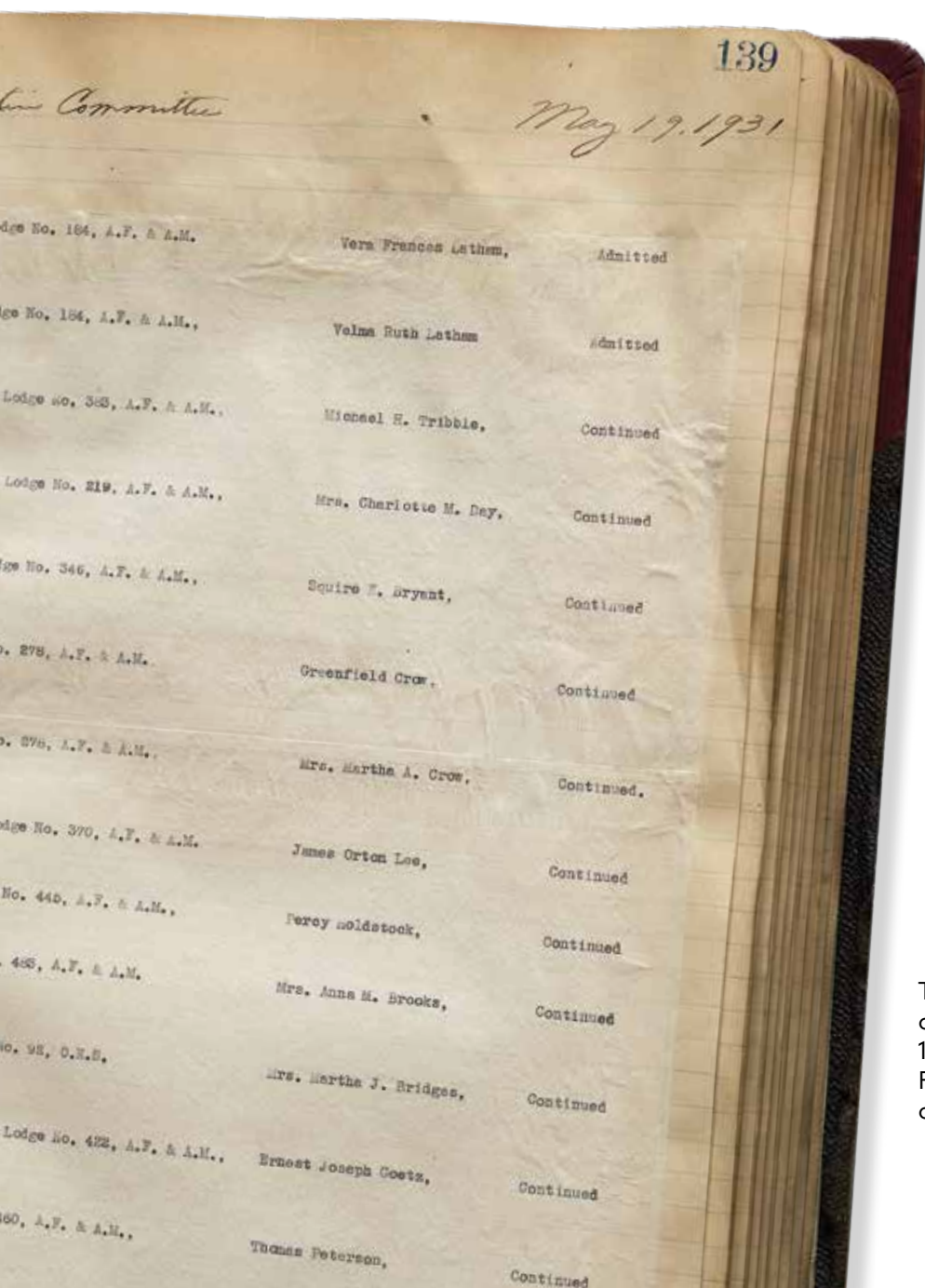
Life at the Masonic Home was structured. Children were housed by age groups, which meant Frances and her sisters rarely saw one another except during meals

in the large dining hall. Amid the routines and quiet hallways, the bonds of family began to form in the smallest of moments.

Frances had never attended school before arriving at the Masonic Home, which made her placement difficult. Unsure of her grade level, teachers passed her around until Miss Leonard, a second-grade teacher, stepped forward. She did not just take Frances into her class; she took her into her heart. She gave her extra work, stayed patient, and helped her catch up. Frances never forgot that kindness. As she grew, she mailed her report cards back to Miss Leonard — her way of saying, “Look, I kept my promise. I made you proud.”

The Masonic Home ensured that every child had opportunities beyond the basics. An organist offered piano lessons to those interested, which Frances eagerly took. On weekends, entertainment was sometimes brought in, or field trips were taken to places like the circus. A hospital on-site ensured doctors and nurses were always available, providing both care and peace of mind.

A tailor on the grounds lovingly repaired clothing, and while the children often wore hand-me-downs, Frances did not think much about it until one day at school when another child



The original ledger from the Masonic Home of Missouri for November 1929 to August 1932. The ledger shows on page 139 when Frances was admitted to the Masonic Home on May 19, 1931.

made a negative comment about someone's clothing. It was then she realized how well they had been cared for — their clothes may not have been new, but they were clean, mended, and given with dignity. These small acts of care helped Frances feel safe, valued, and loved.

Holidays at the Masonic Home were moments of joy. Each child created a list of three Christmas wishes with a designated price limit, and on Christmas Day, gifts were opened together in the dining hall. "I remember they were always nice gifts," Frances recalled. For those who did not have family to visit during the holidays, the Masonic Home gave them a small amount of money — just enough for a movie ticket and a little memory of joy.

As Frances continued her education, the Masonic Home made sure her dreams did not end at high school. She received a scholarship to attend Washington University in St. Louis, where she met the man who would become her husband — a man who also knew of the Masonic Home through a relative. When they married, Frances returned to the place that raised her. She walked down the aisle in the Masonic Home's chapel, escorted by the superintendent at the time.

She and her husband were married for seventy-two years and raised three children. When Frances turned 100 this past April, she reflected on how the Masonic Family and the Masonic Home provided a foundation of love and support that stayed with her throughout her life.



Historical photo of the Hospital (left) and Administration & Children's Building (right) located on the Masonic Home's campus in St. Louis.



Historical photo of older children who resided at the Home. Frances' two sisters, Ruth and Ella are pictured in the front row.

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From Past to Present: The Masonic Home Today

The closing of the original Masonic Home on Delmar Street marked not an end, but a new beginning. Once a residence for Masonic widows and orphans, the Masonic Home's mission expanded beyond its walls, evolving into a statewide network of outreach that now supports the Masonic Family and extends compassion even to those without Masonic ties.

Today, the Masonic Home's Outreach Programs allow care far beyond a single campus. These programs allow the Masonic Home to support the Masonic Family — including seniors, widows, and children — while also extending a helping hand to those with no Masonic connection, just as it once did for Frances and her sisters. Whether providing financial assistance to aging adults, helping children access necessities, or honoring veterans for their service, the Masonic Home's Outreach Programs ensure that compassion is not limited by geography or affiliation.

Widows continue to hold a meaningful place in the Masonic Home's story. Each is recognized with a personalized lapel pin and a card reflecting her spouse's Masonic record — a heartfelt reminder that she is remembered and remains part of the Masonic Family. In Fiscal Year 2025, the Masonic Home reached 6,523 Missouri Masonic widows, offering comfort,

acknowledgment, and a lasting sense of belonging.

Through the Creating-A-Partnership (CAP) Program, the Masonic Home extends support to children across Missouri — without requiring any Masonic affiliation. Lodges and Chapters work with schools and

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community agencies to identify unmet needs, whether it is a child without proper shoes, a class lacking essential supplies, or unpaid lunch balances creating hardship. When a need is recognized, members raise funds,

and the Masonic Home matches their effort, tripling the impact. In this way, CAP carries forward the same spirit of compassion that once embraced Frances and her sisters, helping ensure children today receive the stability, dignity, and hope they need.

The Masonic Home's commitment to service also reaches Missouri veterans through the Partnering To Honor (PTH) Program. With no requirement for Masonic affiliation, PTH supports Honor Flights, care packages for active and retired service members, and clothing for veterans in hospitals. Just as Frances experienced the kindness of a community that stepped in when she needed it most, today's veterans are met with respect, gratitude, and meaningful assistance.

Today, the Masonic Home's family stretches across the state, no longer confined to a single campus. Lodges, Chapters, and supporters who step forward when they see a need now build its "walls." The heart remains unchanged; only the reach has grown.

Just as Frances once found care, stability, and belonging from a home she did not originally know, today's children, widows, seniors, and veterans continue to find support from a home that shows up wherever it is needed — a home still grounded in family.



Portrait of William W. Martin that hangs in the Living Well Gallery of the Missouri Masonic Museum.

William W. Martin and Wilmoth Waller

A Legacy of Caring

By Barbara Ramsey

When the Masonic Home of Missouri built the Missouri Masonic Museum, one of the five galleries was designed specifically to celebrate and highlight the residents and leaders of the Masonic Home located on Delmar Boulevard in St. Louis, Missouri. This gallery is known as the Living Well Gallery. There are many important people celebrated in this gallery that left their lasting impact on the Masonic Home. Two of those individuals are William W. Martin and Wilmoth Waller.

It is impossible to know the full impact of M.W. Martin and Sister Waller's legacy. Both served the Masonic Home at the height of the demand for care. They served through the impacts of the Great Depression and World War II. Not only was the demand for care at its highest, but those events stressed the Masonic Home's financial stability while also dealing with scarcity. We celebrate the stories of these two remarkable individuals.

William Wesley Martin

On March 7, 1879, William Wesley Martin was born in DeKalb, Missouri. At the age of seven, his family moved to Colby, Kansas. The family would return to Missouri roughly nine years later, settling in Doniphan, Missouri.

William was in high school during the time they lived in Colby, Kansas, but he went to the University of Missouri, Columbia, graduating with a Bachelor of Science degree. Miss Leila Johnson was from Columbia, Missouri, and they married on January 1, 1901. They were blessed with three children: Harold, Elizabeth Ann, and John Wesley.

William and Leila lived in Doniphan. William began his career as a clerk in a drug store, then he took the examination by the State Board of Health to become a registered pharmacist. After achieving this, he owned and operated a drug store in Doniphan. At the same time, he owned and operated a 500-acre

farm in Ripley County. In 1923, he was elected a director of the Federal Land Bank of St. Louis. He also served on the boards of trustees for the following organizations: Shurtleff College; William Jewell College; YMCA; Goodwill Industries; Farm Credit Administration; and Children's Home Society. He was a member of the Missouri State Historical Society, I.O.O.F., and held various other civic offices and chairmanships.

William was a member of the Baptist Church, and he would become recognized as one of the most influential laymen in the State. He served as President of the Missouri State B.Y.P.U. from 1909 to 1918. He served as president of the board of trustees of the Third Baptist Church, and he was elected to the General Council of the Northern Baptist Convention in 1947.

Brother Martin found Freemasonry in Composite Lodge No. 369 in his hometown of Doniphan. He became a Missouri

Master Mason on March 24, 1903. He became Worshipful Master of the Lodge in 1905. He was appointed District Deputy Grand Master and District Deputy Grand Lecturer that same year, serving both for the next ten years. Grand Master Frank R. Jesse appointed him to the Grand Lodge Line in 1915. In October 1925, he was elected Grand Master of the Grand Lodge of Missouri.

M.W. Martin was a member of the Scottish Rite bodies in St. Louis, a member of all the York Rite bodies in Popular Bluff, a charter member of the Red Cross of Constantine in the City of Springfield (later transferring his membership to St. Louis), a member in Alhambra Grotto, a member of Missouri Lodge of Research, and a member of Moolah Temple of the Shrine. M.W. Brother Martin was also an active member of the Missouri Order of the Eastern Star serving as Grand Patron 1928-1929. In all organizations, he was considered an excellent ritualist.

Despite all of his accolades and accomplishments, PGM Martin is most remembered for his service to the Masonic Home. He began serving on the Masonic Home Board in 1926. In 1929, he became President of the Masonic Home Board. Due to other administrative changes that same year, he also began to serve as the Masonic Home Superintendent. PGM Martin served as both President of the Board and Superintendent until 1946 when a new Superintendent was hired. He continued to serve on the Board of Directors and as President until 1950.

The Great Depression was a period of high unemployment, poverty, and scarcity that began in 1929 and continued to 1939. The year PGM Martin became President and Superintendent became one of the most difficult times in our country. It was during this time that the need for the Home's assistance was stressed almost beyond capacity. This was coupled with the impact of the stock market crash and subsequent economic effects of the depression. There was a significant loss in membership, which caused the Masonic Home to lose much needed revenue due to the decrease in per capita. In addition, the Home suffered losses in investments in the Endowment Fund.

During the Great Depression, unemployed Freemasons bunked in hospital rooms and storage areas. The Home's census reached its peak in 1933, and the lack of space forced PGM Martin and the governing Board to turn unemployed Brothers and their families back to their local Lodges for assistance. Still, there were adults living in the hospital waiting for rooms in the residence halls. In the middle of the depression, PGM Martin and the Board of Directors courageously began a building campaign.

In 1938, the Home would open a nine-story brick Women's Building. A typical floor contained 15 single bedrooms. This dormitory-style building had rooms for 105 women, a community kitchen, and dining rooms. This helped provide much needed space to address the

overcrowded situation affecting the Home. When World War II began in 1939, the Home once again had to defer maintenance, because they were unable to hire skilled labor or purchase building materials.

By 1942, PGM Martin was once again trying to raise money to build cottages for a new Children's Home. However, he was faced with new challenges and needs to keep the existing structures functioning. The Home needed a new power plant, a new hospital, and a new men's building. The new children's cottages would not come to fruition. By the time PGM Martin left the Board in 1950, the demographics of the residents living in the Home had shifted. Only 13% of the residents were children. The majority of the residents were elderly, with women making up 65% of the residents.

After retiring from his service to the Masonic Home, Martin remained in St. Louis. On August 21, 1962, Martin passed away at the Missouri Baptist Hospital at the age of 83. At the time of his passing, he was the senior Past Grand Master.

In the two years prior to PGM Martin's passing, the Masonic Home received roughly \$2.5 million dollars. The trusts under which those funds were distributed had been created 25 years prior. Those trusts had been established during a time of great need and great leadership by the Masonic Home. In his role of leadership for the Home, Martin understood more than anyone the need for funding for both the children and adults under his care at that time, as well as those in the future.



Historical photo of the Masonic Home's Administration & Children's Building.



Portrait of Wilmoth Waller that hangs in the Living Well Gallery of the Missouri Masonic Museum.

Wilmoth Waller

Wilmoth Waller was born in Randolph County to William Fletcher and Eliza Jane Bolen Harris. She was the youngest child in her family, but she began to help care for her niece when she was only six years old. As she grew, she was the “self-appointed nurse and guardian to half the smaller children in the neighborhood.” She began teaching at the age of seventeen in the Huntsville schools, where she taught for four years before she married John D. Waller of St. Louis. Wilmoth and John were not blessed with children of their own, but she once again found herself caring for a niece after they married.

In 1918, John passed away. Two years later, Mrs. Waller became matron for the children at the Masonic Home in St. Louis.

When Mrs. Waller arrived at the Masonic Home in April of 1920, she worked for Mrs. Mabel E. Engle as one of the governesses. Mrs. Engle became ill, so Mrs. Waller was appointed acting matron. In July, Mrs. Engle resigned, and Mrs. Waller was elected Matron in September. Mrs. Waller was Matron of Children from 1920-1952. Mrs. Waller was not “Mrs.” to the children; rather, she was called “Mother Waller,” as were the governesses who worked under her.

Mother Waller was responsible for the care and well-being of every child in the Home. She was responsible for overseeing staff that cared for the children, as well as providing care for the children themselves. According to

an article in the Missouri Grand Lodge Bulletin, Volume 4, No. 2, Mother Waller was not stern or aloof; rather, she was gentle and loving toward the children in her care. She wanted to know how each child was doing – their health, schoolwork, appearance, and happiness. She would often help in the selection of clothing for the children, because the Masonic Home did not require



Wilmoth Waller smiles with a little boy outside the Masonic Home.

uniforms. Although new clothing for every child was not an option, great care was taken to make sure the children looked well kept.

Mrs. Waller earned the devotion of the children in the Home and the love and respect of those with whom she worked. Upon retiring

from the Masonic Home in 1952, she returned to Huntsville. She was a charter member of Dorothy Chapter #130, O.E.S., at Huntsville, Missouri. She was also an active member of the Huntsville First Baptist Church. Sister Waller had a stroke March 5, 1960. She never regained her strength, and she passed away in July 1961.

Life at the Masonic Home

In 1931, there were almost 150 children living in the Masonic Home. How did Mr. Martin and Mrs. Waller run a home that cared for so many children in a single year? They accomplished this with a good “system and order without severe restraint.” This meant a schedule for bedtimes and meals, good wholesome food, time for play, household responsibilities for those old enough, and school.

The children all lived in the Administration Building. Mornings would begin at 7:00 a.m. with the children being ready for the breakfast bell at 7:15. The children would file into breakfast in an orderly fashion with the youngest girls first followed by the youngest boys. The older girls would follow, then the older boys. Mother Waller would lead the children in a blessing. The older boys selected to help that week would then bring the trays of hot food to the tables.

Each table would have either a governess or two older girls to help serve the food and assist the smaller children. The children were not restricted from talking, but they were required to all finish



Historical photo of children living at the Masonic Home playing on the playground.

their meals at the same time to leave their tables together. The older girls assigned to help with cleaning the dishes remained after the children left. After their task was completed, the girls would be replaced by assigned older boys to sweep and mop the floors around the tables. By a little after 8:00 a.m., all of the children's work was done, and the children got ready to attend schools.

Life at the Masonic Home was not all about school and chores. The children were given opportunities to sing, learn the piano, and play sports. On Friday evenings, all the children assembled in the dining room where they would play records or someone would play the piano. The children could dance or play games. Mother Waller was often asked to join the children, and she joyfully did so at their request.

The children who enjoyed singing would have regular rehearsals in preparation for

Sunday school music in the chapel built by the Order of the Eastern Star. Occasionally, the children would sing two or three songs after dinner as well, to the delight of the other children.

The Home's children who participated in school athletics had their own built-in cheering squad that was not only large in size but enthusiastic. Many of the children of the Home were talented in athletics, receiving honors, and both boys and girls participated in available school athletics.

Mother Waller would often find her way to the nursery in the evenings to assist the governesses in helping the youngest residents of the Home with bedtime. The children would gather on the

floor for their evening prayer, repeating it in unison, and sing their goodnight song. Each in turn would be kissed goodnight and encouraged to go to sleep.

The stories of Martin and Waller remind us of the true meaning of Brotherly Love, Relief, and Truth. They gave of themselves to care for the children left in their charge, but they could not have done it without the support of the membership to fund the Home's operations, provide food, clothing, furnishings, playgrounds, and higher education expenses for interested children. It is the generosity of the Fraternity — in partnership with Martin and Waller — that helped ensure the children of the Home received this loving care.

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A Legacy of Compassion:

Three Generations of Giving from the Heart

By Molly Rhodes

Some legacies are built from wealth or recognition. Others are shaped quietly—through kindness, service, and a steadfast belief in helping others. For this family, generosity is not simply a tradition; it is a reflection of who they are and what they stand for.

By the age of fifteen, Delano Ricket lost both of his parents within four months of each other. Suddenly, he and his six siblings were orphans. That loss, early in life, taught him something that would guide every decision that followed: when you have known hardship, you recognize how vital it is to help someone else through his or hers.

“I think that made a huge impression on him,” said his daughter, Sister Cindy Brock.

Now a fifty-year Mason, Brother Delano has lived a life of service, from his time in the Navy and Air Force to his continued involvement in his Lodge and charitable giving. His family’s story is one of faith, resilience, and generosity that has extended across three generations of giving to the Masonic Home of Missouri.

A Life of Service and Purpose

After Delano’s wife passed away, he moved into a Veterans

Home, beginning a new chapter in his life. Not long after, he began talking with his daughter, Cindy, about wanting to do more philanthropically.

“He’s always been very fruitful in giving to causes that he felt very strongly about,” Cindy said.

“Giving to
the Masonic
Home makes
me feel
blessed.”

—Cindy Brock

When discussing which organizations he wanted to support financially, Delano mentioned one of them being the Masonic Home of Missouri.

“He said he wanted to give back to the Masons,” Cindy said. “He said he has been blessed to have his care taken care of and he wanted to

be able to help his Brothers.”

While the VA covers Delano’s care, he understands that not every Brother or Sister has access to the same support. He knew that the Masonic Home of Missouri has Financial Assistance Programs that often step in to provide that critical help, whether it is allowing someone to remain in their home or assisting with care expenses.

Every year, Cindy helps her father make his contributions, both to his Lodge and to the Masonic Home of Missouri. It is not just a donation; it is a shared expression of gratitude, service, and the Masonic promise to care for one another.

Cindy explained that her father has always made sure she and her family are taken care of and that extends to his Masonic Family as well.

Lessons of Compassion

Parents have a powerful influence on their children’s values, traditions, and approach to giving. For Cindy, her father’s guidance on compassion became the foundation of how she lives and gives.

Delano always taught Cindy to give back because it is not always visible what someone is going

through. She, too, knew what it meant to face hardship.

"I struggled as a single parent. My ex did not pay a whole lot of child support, and I struggled a lot of times. My mom and dad were always there to help me," Cindy said.

Those lessons of compassion and giving became the foundation of how she raised her own daughter, Keva.

With being raised by a member of the Fraternity, Cindy felt drawn to continue that tradition by joining the Order of the Eastern Star—a society built on service, community, and care.

As a member of the Order of the Eastern Star, Cindy knew that part of their dues supported the Masonic Home, but watching her father give personally inspired her to do even more — donating to the Masonic Home.

Keva grew up surrounded by that same spirit of generosity. Guided by both her grandfather and mother, she learned early on the importance of helping others. She also joined the Masonic Family by joining Job's Daughters at the age of twelve and later the Order of the Eastern Star.

Giving Through Generations

Today, Keva's time is largely devoted to caring for her seven-year-old son, Nash, who was born with a heart condition. Navigating medical care, insurance challenges, and the emotional toll of raising a child with health struggles has deepened her understanding of what it means to receive help and why giving back matters.

Joining alongside her family, within the last year she and her husband have decided to give to the Masonic Home.

Through her own experiences, Keva has come to see giving not only as a duty, but also as a way of honoring the help her family has received over the years. When Nash was born with a heart

condition, there were moments of fear and uncertainty, but there were also organizations and people who stepped forward to say, "We want to help."

"Nash is successful because of all the money, in my opinion, that got put into him and he is thriving," Keva said. "It wasn't just injecting money into him. There



The family gathers for a photo. Pictured left to right: Keva, Nash, Delano, and Cindy.

were organizations, similar to this [the Masonic Home], that said, 'We want to help. We want to pay for this. We want to provide what he needs.'"

Now, as life has become more stable, Keva feels a strong responsibility to give back. "I am in a position where I do not need as much assistance anymore," she said. "So, to me, the only fair thing to do is to give back and help others."

The Masonic Home holds special meaning for Keva because of her family's deep ties to Masonry. "If we didn't have the

VA, my grandfather might have needed to turn to the Masonic Home for support," she said.

"We've been very blessed that he hasn't had to but my mom knows people who have. There may be a time that she may have to receive [care], or I may have to receive [care], and so I feel like we're also paying it forward."

The Heart of Giving

For this family, giving is personal. Their generosity stems not from obligation, but from gratitude, faith, and lived experience. Each generation

has faced challenges, from Delano's childhood in the foster care system, to Cindy's years as a single parent, to Keva's journey raising a child with a heart condition. Those struggles shaped their understanding of compassion and the importance of helping others.

Their story reflects what national studies have shown: motivation for giving often comes from personal values and experiences. According to the 2025 Bank of America Study of Philanthropy, 68 percent of affluent donors say their values and beliefs are the top factor guiding where they give. Nearly nine in ten say that giving brings them personal fulfillment.

Even as the ways people give evolve, personal giving remains the foundation of philanthropy. The Giving USA 2025 report found that Americans donated an estimated 592.5 billion dollars to charitable causes in 2024, and nearly two-thirds of that came from individuals. It is a reminder that the collective impact of personal giving continues to sustain organizations that strengthen communities, such as the Masonic Home of Missouri.

For families like this one, giving is more than a tradition—it is a legacy. It is about passing on the values of compassion, generosity, and community service to future generations. As Delano, Cindy, and Keva demonstrate, philanthropy is not just about how much you give, but why you give and how those values ripple outward to touch the lives of others.



Cindy, Keva, and her husband, Matt, gather for a picture at the 20th Annual Truman Club Dinner.

“We are part of the Masonic Family. I feel like this is the first obligation we have.”

—Keva David



Delano holding his grandson, Nash, on his lap as he plays a video game.

A Masonic Legacy of Love

This family's story of generational giving is unique; it is rooted in a Masonic legacy. The Masonic tradition emphasizes unity, brotherly love, and compassion, values that extend not only to members, but also to the entire Masonic Family and the communities they serve.

“We are part of the Masonic Family,” Keva said. “I feel like this is the first obligation we have.”

The Masonic Home of Missouri carries that mission forward through ten Outreach Programs that serve Masons, their wives or widows, children, or veterans. Its reach extends across the entire state and one hundred percent of donations go directly toward assisting clients in need.

“If we can be a small part to

help them [our Brothers and Sisters] live a comfortable life in their old age, or help a struggling family with some medical bills for a child or themselves, then that is a great blessing for us and them,” Keva said.

You may never meet the individuals you help or know the paths they have walked, but your support ensures that someone in need receives comfort, relief, and hope.

“Giving to the Masonic Home makes me feel blessed,” Cindy said. “My family gives because we have seen struggles. We know struggles, and we are able to help others through those struggles.”

A Legacy That Endures

Three generations of giving have built a legacy of compassion

in this family. The values passed down from Delano to Cindy, and from Cindy to Keva, have become a testament to perseverance and generosity. Each generation has faced challenges, but none has allowed hardship to stop them from extending a helping hand to others.

“I had everything I ever wanted and more,” Keva said. “Because he [Delano] always wanted to make our lives easier than the road he had to tow.”

That desire to make someone else's road a little smoother is what defines this family's legacy. Through compassion, faith, and Masonic service, their generosity continues to ripple outward, touching lives across Missouri and inspiring others to give from the heart.

LEGACY



The Truman Club

A Society of the Masonic Home of Missouri

The Truman Club

The Truman Club recognizes those loyal individuals who support the Masonic Home of Missouri with ongoing, annual giving.



The Vincil Society

A Society of the Masonic Home of Missouri

The Vincil Society

The Vincil Society recognizes financial support of Lodges, Chapters, and other organizations for the Masonic Home of Missouri.



The Schneider Legacy Society

A Society of the Masonic Home of Missouri

The Schneider Legacy Society

Those who remember the Masonic Home of Missouri through a will, trust, beneficiary designation or other planned gifts are invited to join The Schneider Legacy Society.



Scan the QR codes above to learn more about the Masonic Home Giving Societies. Members can contact Sr. Engagement & Major Gifts Officer, Jackie Walters, at (800) 434-9804 to join a society.

Seeing the Need, Becoming the Support

By Molly Rhodes

During winter, seeing a child walk to the school bus without a coat can stop you in your tracks. The first thought might be, “Why would a parent let their child leave the house like that?” However, the reality is far different — that child may come from a family simply unable to afford a warm coat this season.

This is exactly the kind of need the Creating-A-Partnership (CAP) Program helps address. By collaborating with Lodges and Chapters across Missouri, the CAP Program identifies and supports children and families in local communities. In Fiscal Year 2025 alone, CAP provided \$1,268,948 in direct assistance, reaching 48,956 children. Support ranged from school supplies and food pantry items to clothing drives and playground equipment — each project tailored to meet specific community needs.

At the Masonic Home of Missouri, we encourage Lodges



WB Steve Banderman presents a CAP check to Monica Hiatt and Shannon Banderman from Lonedell School.

and Chapters to be the eyes and ears of their communities. You may notice a student without proper winter clothing, or hear of a school struggling to provide hygiene items or classroom supplies. These small observations can spark meaningful change. Without your awareness and involvement, many children in need might otherwise go unseen.

As the cost of food, clothing, and daily essentials continues to rise, families, teachers, and students all feel the strain. Lodges and Chapters can make a powerful difference by identifying local needs, raising funds, and collaborating with the Masonic Home to provide essential support — helping children not just meet basic needs, but thrive both academically and personally.

Through the CAP Program, we become an extension of family — supporting children, schools, and organizations across Missouri. Together, we can ensure every child has the resources, encouragement, and opportunity to succeed.

CAP In Action

Across Missouri, Lodges and Chapters are proving that when Masons work together, even the smallest efforts can create lasting impact.

Easter Lodge No. 575 has supported several CAP projects



Fulton Chapter #35 presents its CAP donation to Cedar Creek Therapeutic Riding Center, supporting new helmets for riders. Pictured left to right: Sister Liz Musgrove, Karen Grindler of Cedar Creek Therapeutic Riding Center, Sister Orvella Wright, and Sister Sue Davis.

in recent years. Most recently, the Lodge raised funds to provide coats for children in need at Richwood R-VII and Lonedell R-XIV. Through the Coats for Kids initiative, they helped bring warmth and comfort to students who might otherwise face the winter without proper clothing. The Lodge raised \$775 for each school, and with the Masonic Home's match, a total of \$2,325 provided 120 new coats for local children.

For Fulton Chapter #35, O.E.S., 2025 marked their very first CAP project — and it showed that even small donations can make a big difference. With many members older or homebound, the Chapter hosted a “no-bake bake sale,” collecting donations through letters and spare change. Their \$530 grew to nearly \$1,600 with the Masonic Home's match, helping Cedar Creek Therapeutic Riding Center purchase new

safety helmets for its riders with disabilities.

“We realized we didn't have to do a big fundraiser to make an

“It's about
community
stepping up —
that's what the
Masonic Family
has always
stood for.”

—Sue Davis

impact,” said Sister Sue Davis. “It's about community stepping up — that's what the Masonic Family has always stood for.”

It is not always a Lodge or Chapter that seeks out an organization in need — sometimes, it is the organization that reaches out to them. That was the case for Samaritan Lodge No. 424 when Rocky Creek Youth Ranch asked for help. The ranch provides a safe and caring home for children ages six to eighteen who have been displaced or orphaned. Initially, the organization reached out seeking assistance to purchase tables for their kitchen.

However, when members of the Lodge toured the facility, they noticed something missing — the children had no playground. Moved by what they saw, the Lodge decided to go beyond their original plan and help create a space where the children could play and simply be kids. They raised \$2,000, and through the Masonic Home of Missouri's Creating-A-Partnership program, that total grew to \$6,000 — a meaningful contribution toward making the playground a reality.

Working Together. Succeeding Together.

Every community has a need waiting to be met — and every Lodge and Chapter has the power to meet it. Whether it is funding winter coats, school supplies, or safety equipment, your partnership through the Creating-A-Partnership (CAP)

Program can change lives in ways both seen and unseen.

Each act of service, no matter how small, sends a powerful message: someone cares. It tells a child that they matter, that their comfort and safety are important, and that their community is looking out for them. It reminds families who are struggling that they are not alone — that the Masonic Family stands beside them in times of need.

When Lodges and Chapters work hand in hand with the Masonic Home of Missouri, compassion becomes action, and action becomes impact. From classrooms and community centers to youth programs and shelters, the reach of CAP extends across Missouri — strengthening not only families, but the very



Samaritan Lodge Members from Samaritan Lodge No. 424, Elvins-Ionic Lodge No. 154, and local volunteers came together to build the new playground at Rocky Creek Youth Ranch.

fabric of our communities.

So, as new needs arise and communities continue to evolve, remember that the smallest spark of compassion can ignite lasting change. Start your CAP project

today — and see just how far your generosity can go.

Together, we are building stronger communities and brighter futures where every child has the opportunity to thrive.

STORIES OF IMPACT

Have a project you would like to see featured?

Email info@mohome.org to share your story!

Want to see more inspiring examples of how Lodges and Chapters are changing lives across Missouri? Visit mohome.org/stories-of-impact





Follow these steps to get involved.

- 1 Visit bit.ly/Creating-A-Partnership
- 2 Download and complete the application.
- 3 Mail the completed application, along with the Lodge and/or Chapter donated funds, to the Masonic Home of Missouri.
 - 📍 Masonic Home of Missouri
6033 Masonic Drive, Suite A
Columbia, MO 65202
- 4 To discuss your request, email or call the Masonic Home of Missouri and request to speak to Tisha Woodard, Partnership Programs Coordinator.
 - 📞 (800) 434-9804
 - ✉️ partnership@mohome.org

Follow us on Facebook (@MasonicHomeofMissouri) as we share more stories and updates on our Creating-A-Partnership Program.



Teachers Filling the Gap

By Gabby Gazaille

Every August, the school year begins with fresh materials neatly arranged on each desk: crayons, pencils, erasers, and scissors ready for eager students. By midyear, many of those essentials are gone, worn down, or taken home, and teachers quietly replace them out of their own paychecks. It is a cycle that repeats month after month, as educators go above and beyond to make sure every child has what they need to learn and thrive.

This generosity speaks volumes, but it should not fall on teachers alone.

Across the country, thousands of teachers are filling the gap by purchasing classroom items, snacks, clothing, and hygiene products for students whose families cannot afford them. According to USA Today, teachers nationwide collectively spent more than \$3.5 billion of their own money on classroom needs during the 2024-2025 school year. In Missouri, where the average starting teacher salary ranks among the lowest in the nation, that burden weighs especially heavily.

According to a recent survey by AdoptAClassroom.org, Missouri

teachers spent an average of \$821 out of pocket on classroom materials during the 2024-2025 school year, a cost that keeps rising.

While some teachers turn to crowdfunding platforms like GoFundMe, Amazon Wish Lists, or DonorsChoose to cover classroom expenses, many others are paying out of pocket, often taking on debt, picking up second jobs, or going without, just to ensure their students have what they need.

Some schools provide small stipends to help offset these

costs, but educators say they rarely stretch far enough. “When you’re thinking of supplies — folders and things like that — they’re not cheap,” one second-grade teacher told USA Today. “You’re buying at least three folders per student just to keep their items organized.” Todd Fuller, spokesperson for the Missouri State Teachers Association, told KSDK5, “The number of Missouri teachers who are not reimbursed for the money they are spending on supplies for their students is larger than I expected it to be.”

As inflation continues to drive up the cost of everyday goods, teachers say their dollars no longer go as far as they used to. The need now extends well beyond notebooks and pencils. Many purchase hygiene items, snacks, and even furniture to create comfortable, safe classrooms where students can thrive. In Title I schools, teachers often keep spare clothing for children who only have one uniform or a single pair of shoes. Others stock toiletries and snacks so students can focus on learning instead of worrying about their basic needs.

In May of 2024, Missouri lawmakers raised the minimum starting salary for teachers to \$40,000, a welcome step forward, but still nearly \$10,000 less than neighboring states such as Arkansas and Illinois. The reality remains: many Missouri educators continue to fill the gap between what schools can provide and what students need.

Creating-A-Partnership Program

Through the Masonic Home of Missouri’s Creating-A-Partnership (CAP) Program, Lodges and Chapters can help fill the gap for local teachers and students.

Lodges and Chapters have used CAP funds to support a wide range of needs, like stocking school food pantries, paying down lunch debt, supporting Buddy Backpack programs, and providing clothing and hygiene products.

Lodges and Chapters can also support teachers by funding:

- Classroom supplies such as crayons, folders, markers, and pencils
- Hygiene items such as toothpaste, deodorant, and personal care items
- Playground equipment
- Seasonal needs such as winter coats, gloves, and hats
- Clothing items such as pants, shoes, shirts, socks

LEARN MORE

To learn more about the Creating-A-Partnership Program, visit mohome.org or call (800) 434-9804.



Good Night's Rest

Why Sleep Matters for Children

By Gabby Gazaille

Some children look forward to bedtime — the comfort of a soft blanket or a favorite stuffed animal. But for those without a bed to call their own or a safe place to sleep, bedtime can be anything but restful. Without that comfort and security, children can struggle to get the sleep they need to learn, grow, and thrive.

Why Sleep Matters

Sleep is essential for a child's development. It strengthens memory, supports learning, and helps with emotional regulation. During sleep, the body and mind recharge so children can wake up ready for a new day.

When children do not get enough sleep, the effects can be serious. Research links poor sleep to higher risks of obesity, type 2 diabetes, anxiety, and depression. In the classroom, insufficient sleep leads to lower grades, trouble concentrating, and reduced problem-solving abilities.

Studies from Harvard University, Auburn University, the National Science Foundation, and the Better Sleep Council show that poor sleep can contribute to hyperactivity as

early as age five. In teenagers, it is strongly connected to anxiety and depression.

When Children Go Without Sleep

The CDC recommends children ages 6-12 get 9-10 hours of sleep each night, while teens need 8-10. Yet more than half of middle schoolers and nearly three-quarters of high schoolers fall short on school nights.

For some students, the issue is not habits — it is their environment. Sleep in Heavenly Peace (SHP), a non-profit that builds and delivers beds, estimates that 2-3% of children nationwide have no bed of their own. "Every child deserves a bed," said Regina Brett in a feature for SHP. "It is a basic need."

Research from Northwestern University's Kellogg Institute suggests that having something of one's own, such as a bed, promotes psychological ownership — a sense of belonging and self-worth that boosts confidence and positive social behavior.

A safe, comfortable place to sleep helps children wake up ready to

learn, connect, and grow into their full potential.

Building Better Sleep Habits

Healthy routines can make a difference. Consistent bedtimes, screen-free bedrooms, and ensuring children get the recommended hours of sleep each night all help them recharge.

Schools can support better sleep as well. The American Academy of Pediatrics recommends that schools start no earlier than 8:30 a.m. so students can get adequate rest. Research also shows that students who take regular midday naps at school experience greater happiness, stronger self-control, fewer behavioral issues, and even higher IQ scores.

By teaching students the importance of sleep and reinforcing healthy habits, educators can improve both academic performance and mental well-being.

Small adjustments — promoting good sleep hygiene, rethinking schedules, and ensuring every child has a bed — can have a big impact on children's health, focus, and confidence.



Sleep In Heavenly Peace

Building Dreams: One Bed at a Time

By Molly Rhodes

Children are often called our future — future leaders, educators, medical professionals, and innovators. Yet, for many children across the United States, something as simple as a good night's sleep is out of reach.

A bed is essential to a child's physical, emotional, and mental development. A bed represents comfort, safety, and a sense of belonging. For a child, it is a place to dream, to heal, and to grow. Without one, children can face sleepless nights, struggle in school, and feel the weight

of uncertainty no child should ever know.

A Mission That Grows

In 2012, a group of volunteers in Idaho noticed too many children sleeping on couches, floors, or makeshift bedding. Determined to make a difference, they founded Sleep in Heavenly Peace (SHP) — a nonprofit organization with a simple but powerful motto: “No kid sleeps on the floor in our town.”

What began as a small community effort has since grown

into a nationwide movement with more than 370 chapters across the United States, as well as chapters in Canada, Bermuda, and the Bahamas. The organization envisions expanding across the entire country in the future and is completely volunteer-driven, with each local chapter responsible for building, delivering, and assembling beds for children in need within their own communities.

Sleep in Heavenly Peace also partners with the foster care system, as children cannot be

placed in foster homes or reunited with their parents without having a bed of their own.

Making a Difference in Missouri

In Columbia, Missouri, the local SHP chapter has delivered over 300 beds to date, a remarkable achievement made possible through the dedication of volunteers and community partnerships. Each bed build brings together people from all walks of life — neighbors, civic groups, schools, and local organizations — united by one shared goal: giving every child a place to rest their head.

The process is simple but powerful. Volunteers cut and

sand lumber, assemble frames, and prepare the finished beds for future delivery. Once the beds are built, the local chapter schedules delivery days where volunteer teams can sign up to help bring the beds to families' homes. During these deliveries, volunteers set up each bed and make it ready for its new owner, complete with a mattress, pillows, and bedding.

These moments often leave a lasting impression. For many volunteers, seeing a child's joy upon receiving their very first bed is a reminder of how even the smallest act of kindness can change a life.

Despite these successes, the need in Columbia remains

significant — 16% of kids in Columbia Public Schools are considered in extreme poverty according to the City of Columbia. Many of those children are in need of a bed. The local chapter continues to work tirelessly to meet that need, one bed at a time.

How to Get Involved

Volunteering with Sleep in Heavenly Peace is open to everyone — no carpentry skills required. All training, tools, and materials are provided. Bed builds are family-friendly and create meaningful opportunities for corporate teams, schools, service clubs, sports teams, faith groups, and community organizations to work together in service.



AGENCY SPOTLIGHT

Ways to get involved include:

- Building or delivering beds during community events
- Organizing a build day for your workplace or group
- Joining a local core team to help lead chapter efforts
- Starting a chapter if one does not exist in your area

SHP also welcomes support through financial donations, in-kind gifts, bedding drives, event hosting, and volunteer partnerships. Whether you are building, donating, or organizing, every contribution helps a child rest easier.

The Impact of Giving

95 cents of every dollar donated goes directly to building beds for children in need. The organization makes two types of beds. A single bed costs \$250 to build and a bunk bed is \$500.

All donations remain within the local chapter and are tax-deductible, ensuring that every contribution benefits children close to home. Sleep in Heavenly Peace is a platinum rated charity with an A+ rating through Guidestar.

When you help a child sleep in a real bed for the first time, you are not just building furniture, you are building confidence, comfort, and a brighter future.

The Emotional Impact

When volunteers are building beds, they often do not know the children who will receive them — only that each bed will make a difference for a child in need. Sleep in Heavenly Peace offers the unique opportunity to see that impact firsthand. Volunteers who take part in bed deliveries often describe it as the most rewarding part of the experience — watching a child's face light up when they see their very own bed, complete

with pillows and blankets, is a moment that stays with you.

The impact extends beyond the child. For many families, a bed represents relief and gratitude, one less worry and one more step toward stability. Parents often express how much it means to know their child has a safe, comfortable place to sleep. It brings peace of mind and a sense of dignity to the entire household. What begins as a simple bed build ends up touching hearts, strengthening families, and building hope within the community.



Learn More about Sleep In Heavenly Peace. Scan the QR code or visit shpbeds.org



Year-End Giving in 2025:

Impacts of the One Big Beautiful Bill Act on Charitable Contributions

By Jodi Blake

The One Big Beautiful Bill Act (OBBBA) was signed into law on July 4, 2025, with changes to charitable giving deductions to take effect on January 1, 2026.

As a result, this holiday season brings opportunity and a little urgency to charitable donors, with 2025 being the last year under the current rules.

The impact to the deductibility of your charitable giving depends on whether you itemize or not. Effective January 1, 2026, those who itemize will have a 0.5% floor on the deduction of charitable contributions, meaning that only charitable contributions that exceed 0.5% of your AGI are deductible. Those who do not itemize will be allowed to deduct up to \$1,000 (single, or \$2,000 joint) in charitable cash contributions to qualified public charities.

If you do not itemize:

Most likely, you won't get a tax deduction for charitable giving in 2025. But, some other provisions of the Act are going into effect this year that may change whether you

can itemize, even if you haven't been. The standard deduction has increased, but so did the state and local tax deduction (SALT). Take a look at your situation before year-end to see if you may be able to itemize.

In 2026, you will be able to deduct contributions as noted above. Non-cash contributions and contributions to donor advised funds (DAFs) are excluded.

To get the most benefit for your generosity, review whether current year tax changes impact whether you can itemize. If you can, ensure that your year-end gift arrives by December 31. If you won't itemize this year, you may want to delay your giving until January 1.

If you itemize:

In 2026, you will only be able to deduct charitable gifts that, when combined, exceed 0.5% of your AGI. In addition, if you are in the 37% tax bracket, you'll only be able to deduct up to the 35% marginal rate.

For the most financially-advantageous gift this holiday season, ensure that your gift is

received by December 31, 2025. You may also want to consider making a larger gift this year to capitalize on the current deduction rules before they expire. This may be a great time for you to donate appreciated assets.

Regardless of whether you itemize or not, here's what every donor should know this year:

- 1.** 2025 Contributions — To count for your 2025 taxes, all donations must be completed by midnight, December 31, 2025. Checks must be postmarked and electronic gifts must be fully processed.
- 2.** Qualified Charitable Deduction (QCD) from your IRA — If you're age 70 ½ or older, you can donate up to \$108,000 directly from your IRA to qualified charities in 2025 without it counting as taxable income. This can count as your required minimum distribution (RMD). You can also use up to \$54,000 of a QCD to make a one-time donation to a

charitable remainder trust or charitable gift annuity. For married couples, you can each donate up to your individual annual limit.

3. Gifts of Appreciated Assets — Donating stocks, bonds, or mutual funds that have increased in value allows you to avoid capital gains taxes while supporting the causes you love.
4. Talk with your Financial or Tax Advisor — Especially since tax rules are changing, talk to your advisor before making large or complex gifts.
5. While tax incentives can guide how we give, they're never the reason why we give. Every contribution, large or small, helps further the reach of the causes you hold dear. This year, as you make your final gifts of 2025, or your first gifts of 2026, know that your generosity matters more than ever. By giving now, you're not just making a difference, you're helping ensure that the spirit of giving remains strong no matter what changes the future brings.

What Masonic Home Donors Should Know:

- Make 2025 contributions by December 31, 2025.
- Our Holiday Appeal will stay open until after the New Year. If the 2026 tax laws are more beneficial to you, send your gift in January and it will still be considered your response to our Holiday Campaign.
- Donations from your IRA are greatly appreciated.
- We offer Charitable Gift Annuities.
- Gifts of appreciated assets are a great way to make a gift. These can take some time, so plan accordingly.
- Always talk with your financial advisor when making major financial decisions. If they need any information from us, we are happy to provide it.

LEARN MORE

Call Jackie Walters to discuss a major gift!
Large or small, every gift helps those who rely on us.
Contact Jackie Walters at jwalters@mohome.org

*The information provided herein is for informational purposes only and should not be construed as tax advice.
Please consult your tax advisor for guidance specific to your financial situation.*

Ways to Give in 2026

Hope for the holidays — what a beautiful gift to give. At this time of year, we know that you receive an overwhelming number of requests to support numerous causes. While every cause may be worthy, most of us are not able to support every cause.

We hope that the mission of the Masonic Home and the lives touched through this organization compel you to choose the children

and adults we help to receive the benefit of your generosity.

The holidays are not the only time these people need you. Their needs arise all year long. Please take a look at the Ways to Give in 2026 as we begin a new, and hopefully prosperous, year. This will give you an idea of when you will receive requests from us, but also all of the ways in which you can financially support

children and adults through the Masonic Home's programs.

From cash to stock and from a holiday appeal gift to a bequest in your will, we need and appreciate your support. We look forward to sharing the next year with you as we work together to impact tens of thousands of lives across this beautiful state. We wish you a wonderful holiday season and a very prosperous New Year.

Here are all of the various ways you can support Masonic Home throughout 2026.

ONLINE CAMPAIGNS

Masonic Home Day
Truman Campaign
Donate Online Anytime

SPONSORSHIP

Sponsor an Event

PLANNED GIVING

Bequests
Charitable Gift Annuity
Charitable Trusts
Gifts of Life Insurance
Stocks & Securities

MONTHLY HAPPENINGS

April – June
Spring Campaign

June
Golf Tournament

November – December
Penny-A-Day
Hope for the Holidays

RECURRING GIFTS

DOUBLE IMPACT

Matching Gifts
Partnership Programs

MEMORIAL

Courtyard Paver
Memorial Gift

MAJOR GIFTS

Qualified Charitable
Distribution from an IRA
Donor Advised Funds
Community Foundations



To learn more about how you can support the Masonic Home
call (800) 434-9804 or visit mohome.org/support

MASONIC HOME NUMBERS

\$1,268,948 > direct assistance provided for children through CAP during FY2025

151

Lodges and Chapters participated in CAP during FY2025

236

number of organizations that received funding through the Partnership Programs in FY2025

142

number of children living in the Masonic Home when Frances was admitted

48,956 children helped through CAP during FY2025

NATIONAL NUMBERS

32%

of fourth graders in the U.S. read below basic proficiency levels
(National Assessment of Educational Progress, 2024)

50%

children from stable family environments are 50% less likely to develop behavioral or emotional problems
(CDC, Adverse Childhood Experiences (ACEs) Study, 2021)

40%

of children have experienced at least one adverse childhood experience, such as abuse or household instability (CDC, 2024)

30% >

children who are food secure are 30% less likely to experience chronic health issues, such as obesity or anemia (Feeding America, Child Hunger and Health Report, 2023)

MISSOURI NUMBERS

38th

Missouri ranks 38th in the nation on per-student spending at \$12,800 per student (National Education Association, Rankings of the States & Estimates of School Statistics, 2023-2024)

47th

Missouri ranks 47th in the nation on average teacher salary of \$53,000 (National Education Association, Rankings of the States & Estimates of School Statistics, 2023-2024)

More than 60%

of rural Missouri counties have a shortage of mental health providers for children and adolescents (MO HealthNet, 2024)

57% of students were less than proficient in English Language Arts on the 2024 Missouri Assessment Program (MAP), **only 43% were proficient** (Missouri Department of Elementary and Secondary Education, 2024 Statewide Assessment Report)

61% of students were less than proficient in Math on the 2024 Missouri Assessment Program (MAP), **only 39% were proficient** (Missouri Department of Elementary and Secondary Education, 2024 Statewide Assessment Report)

897,000 approximate number of students enrolled in Missouri's public K-12

(Missouri Department of Elementary and Secondary Education)

17%

of Missouri children live below the federal poverty level, about 1 in 6 children (U.S. Census Bureau, 2024)

Over
12,000

children are in Missouri's foster care system (Children's Division, 2024)

26%

of families with children under 5 face housing cost burdens (Kids Count Missouri, 2024)



MWB Kevin M. Fuller

What has your experience been like as a Board Member of the Masonic Home? And what committee did you serve on and for how long?

Over the past five years, as a member of the Advancing Grand Line and Grand Master, I have served on every committee supporting the Masonic Home of Missouri. The experience is unlike anything else I have experienced in Freemasonry...The Masonic Home of Missouri offers the ability to pool our resources through the “power of the collective” and make a massive impact on our communities and those that need our help.

If you could give one piece of advice to a new board member, what would it be?

When dealing with all of the challenges that an organization of this size has to face, don't ever forget about the clients. Everything the Masonic Home does is for the clients. If you keep them in mind, the magnitude of the challenges will feel insignificant compared to the impact that is being made.



RWB Jim D. Hardy

What has your experience been like as a Board Member of the Masonic Home? And what committees did you serve on and for how long?

It has been the most rewarding experience serving on the board. I served on Outreach for one year and was able to see the effort and assistance the Home does for people. I served three years in the Finance committee, two of which I was Chairman and Treasurer for the Home. On this committee, I was able to bring my background as a CPA to assist the Home in financial compliance with law and regulations.

Why do you feel like supporting the Masonic Home is important to you?

The Home helps all Masons serve our Brothers, Sisters, and the community at large through its many programs. It is a great reason to be a Mason.



RWB Gale F. Bennington

When did you get involved with Masonry?

My introduction to Masonry was profoundly influenced by my father, who was a Master Mason. He was a man I always respected and admired, not only within our family but in the broader business community. His strong character and the respect he commanded left a lasting impression on me. My father's integrity and values served as a guiding light, shaping my own aspirations and beliefs.

Why do you feel like supporting the Masonic Home is important to you?

Serving and supporting the Masonic Home is a true privilege. Through my involvement, I have witnessed firsthand the extensive assistance provided to individuals in need...This experience has been eye-opening, illustrating the profound impact that collective efforts can have on the lives of those we serve. By actively participating in this work, I have deepened my appreciation for the values of compassion and service that are at the heart of Masonry.

SAVE THE DATE



MASONIC HOME
of Missouri

Annual Charity Golf Tournament

June 8, 2026

Columbia Country Club • 9 a.m. Shotgun Start



To learn more about Lodge and Chapter sponsorship opportunities,
call (800) 434-9804 or email info@mohome.org.



MASONIC HOME
of Missouri

6033 Masonic Drive, Suite A, Columbia, MO 65202 • (800) 434-9804 • mohome.org